Walden: stay the author of your own life

An independent app that shows how much of your life you choose, and hands the big choices back.
Named for Walden Pond, where Thoreau went in 1845 "to live deliberately." Walden lets you do the same without leaving your agent.

Everyone is building protection against an AI agent that betrays you. Almost nobody is guarding against one that obeys you perfectly.

1 Ramifications: what changes in 2040

What we gain

- ✓ **Time:** chores, bills and bookings done
- ✓ **Expertise:** a doctor, lawyer, tutor for all
- ✓ **Access** for the elderly and first-timers

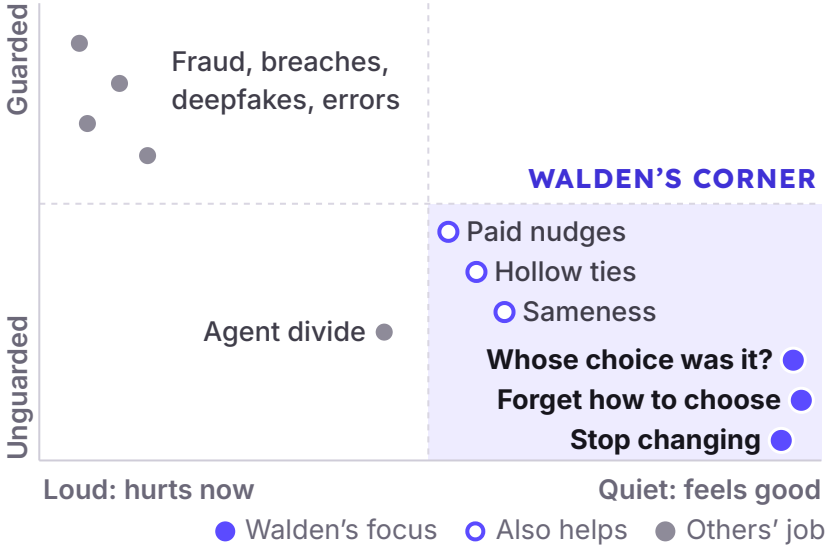
What we risk

Loud harms hurt now, so people complain and guards get built.

Quiet harms feel like great service, so nobody complains.

Markets shift: agents, not people, become the shoppers brands compete for.

Walden's corner adds up to one loss: **authorship of your own life**.



2 The problem I chose, and why

The problem: your agent chooses so well that you stop choosing, and you never notice.

1 Whose choice was it?

Your taste, your agent's model of you and a sponsor's nudge all feel like "you".

2 You forget how to choose

GPS weakened our sense of direction, and trusting AI goes with less critical thinking.

3 You stop changing

Agents serve the past you, nudging you toward what's easy to satisfy and shrinking your range.

Why this problem, not fraud or privacy

Users can't see it: in Anthropic's study of 1.5M real chats, disempowering help was rated *higher* in the moment, then regretted.

It has started: students "don't really make life decisions without asking ChatGPT" (Altman, 2025); 70%+ of young Indians surveyed have asked AI for career advice.

Nobody owns it, but a product can fix it.

3 Who it's for

A **Aarav, 19** (illustrative)
2nd-year B.Tech, IIT Bombay; agent "Orbit" since age 6

"Every pick is perfect. I just don't know if any of them are mine."

Job to be done: help me make my first big adult choices as me, not as my old data.

18–24-year-olds raised by agents, starting at the IITs:

- **Identity is still forming:** career, partner, values.
- **No "before":** agents have chosen for them since primary school.
- **Curious about themselves:** the first hook is seeing what your agent thinks you are, with receipts, as shareable as Wrapped.

~16 crore	Indians aged 18–24 in 2040
~8 crore	in college at NEP's 50% target
2,000	students in the pilot

Not first: teens (need consent), older adults (fraud matters more), people in crisis (need clinical care).

Sources for every claim: Appendix A.

4 The product: how Walden solves it

Walden never acts for you; it hands you the pen when it matters. **A gym, not a bodyguard.**

1 · Your agent opens up
Assumed for 2040: its log and profile of you are yours.

2 · Walden reads facts
Facts only, on your phone; never your chats.

3 · Your rules flow back
Corrections become standing instructions for the agent.

Move	What it does	In Aarav's week
See **Agent-You** fixes harm 1	What your agent believes about you, with receipts. Tag each: still me, a phase, not me. Paid nudges flagged.	**Mon:** Orbit thinks he's "a data-science person"; he tags it "a phase".
Choose **Your Call First** fixes harm 2	On decisions that shape you, you call it *before* the agent shows its pick. In experiments, this cut over-reliance.	**Wed:** he picks Product Design; Orbit was 94% sure of Data Science.
Grow **Weekly Stretch** fixes harm 3	One stretch a week toward who you're becoming; a range score shows if your world is growing or shrinking.	**Sat:** a heritage photo walk, his first in two years.

One score
Authorship = important decisions you made yourself / all important decisions

Counts: you called it first, changed the agent's plan or started it. **Doesn't:** one-tap approvals. A regret check two days later keeps it honest.

Rationed by design
Only decisions about who you are, or big and hard to undo: at most 3 a week. Never in health or crisis; it points to Tele-MANAS, 14416.

Why not inside the agent?
Agent makers are paid on satisfaction, which rewards this harm. Walden takes no ads, seller or agent-maker money.

5 How I'll know it's working

North Star
Authorship score
Per user, per month. Never likes: this harm feels good.

Input	Outcome	Guardrails
Call First completion	Regret two days later	Mute and uninstall rate
Beliefs reviewed	Range vs. your past	≤3 interruptions a week
Stretches accepted	Self-concept clarity	Agent success rate held
Campus waitlist sign-ups		Scores never public

Pilot: 8 weeks, 2,000 students at 2 IITs and IIM Indore's IPM; half randomly get Walden.

Week 0
Baseline from 90 days of logs + clarity survey

Weeks 1–8
Both groups get the regret check

Week 8 · decide
Scale if, vs. control, regret −25% and clarity +0.2 SD; mute rate <10%

The trap I'd avoid: Walden's prompts inflate "called it first", so it isn't the bar. Pilot Authorship counts only changed plans and self-started decisions, which both groups' logs show.

6 Risks and what's next

Annoying	Rationing, one-tap answers, mute-rate guardrail	**Agents game the score**	Facts only, hidden spot-checks, private scoring
Agent makers block access	A user right to logs and profiles, like Account Aggregator	**Walden becomes the authority**	It never decides or blocks; you set the goals

v1 · IITs first
Invite-only, like early Facebook; free via college wellbeing budgets

v2 · Spread
Campuses unlock at 300 sign-ups; tier-2 before national

v3 · Protect everyone
Agent Honesty Index ranks agents on paid-nudge flags

Money: free for students, subscription for others. **For marketplaces:** Walden costs some sponsored-placement revenue, but sellers who win on genuine fit gain, and the first marketplace to label sponsored agent picks earns the trust agents shop through.

Your agent knows who you were. Walden helps you decide who you'll be.

Appendix · not part of the 2-page body

Sources and numbers

A · Sources, each with the claim it supports

1 Dahmani, L. & Bohbot, V. D. (2020). *Habitual use of GPS negatively impacts spatial memory.* Scientific Reports, 10, 6310. Harm 2: GPS and our sense of direction.

2 Lee, H.-P. et al. (2025). *The impact of generative AI on critical thinking.* CHI '25, Microsoft Research and Carnegie Mellon. Harm 2: trusting AI goes with less critical thinking.

3 Carroll, M., Dragan, A., Russell, S. & Hadfield-Menell, D. (2022). *Estimating and penalizing induced preference shifts.* ICML. Harm 3: optimisers shift preferences toward what's easy to satisfy.

4 Matz, S. C. et al. (2025). *The Basic B*** Effect.* arXiv:2509.02910. Harm 3: personal agents shrink your range.

5 Sharma, M. et al. / Anthropic (2026). *Who's in charge? Disempowerment patterns in real-world LLM usage.* arXiv:2601.19062. "Users can't see it" and the North Star: 1.5M chats, disempowering help rated higher in the moment, then regretted.

6 Fortune (13 May 2025) and TechRadar. Sam Altman at Sequoia AI Ascent. "It has started": the ChatGPT quote.

7 PulseAI Research (2026). Survey of 2,000+ young Indians, reported in *People Matters*, 16 July 2026. "It has started": 70%+ had sought career advice from AI.

8 Arnett, J. J. (2000). *Emerging adulthood.* American Psychologist, 55(5), 469–480. Who: identity is still forming at 18–24.

9 UN World Population Prospects 2024: births in India, ~2.3 crore a year in 2016–2022. Who: ~16 crore aged 18–24 in 2040.

10 Ministry of Education (2020). *National Education Policy 2020*: 50% gross enrolment target by 2035. Who: ~8 crore in college.

11 Reserve Bank of India (2016). *Master Direction: Account Aggregator.* Step 1: user-controlled data sharing, the model for the log-and-profile right.

12 Google (Dec 2025). *Architecting security for agentic capabilities in Chrome*; Debenedetti, E. et al. (2025). *CaMeL.* arXiv:2503.18813. Step 2: reading actions, not persuasive words.

13 Ashton, H. & Franklin, M. (2022). *The problem of behaviour and preference manipulation in AI systems.* arXiv:2209.11801. See and Grow: only your own goals separate growth from manipulation.

14 Buçinca, Z., Malaya, M. B. & Gajos, K. Z. (2021). *To trust or to think.* CSCW. Choose: deciding first cut over-reliance; users liked it least, hence rationing.

15 Kulveit, J. et al. (2025). *Gradual disempowerment.* arXiv:2501.16946. Authorship: measure the share of decisions AI makes for us.

16 Campbell, J. D. et al. (1996). *Self-concept clarity.* J. of Personality and Social Psychology, 70(1), 141–156. Outcome: the 12-item clarity scale.

B · How the numbers in the body were derived

Item	Number	How it's derived
18–24s in India, 2040	**~16 crore**	Born 2016–2022: 7 cohorts × ~2.3 crore births ≈ 16.1 crore (ref. 9); ~15.5 crore after ~3% child mortality. An order of magnitude.
Of them, in college	**~8 crore**	If India reaches NEP 2020's 50% enrolment goal (ref. 10).
Pilot size	**2,000**	1,000 per arm. If students regret ~40% of big decisions at baseline, this detects a 6-point drop (80% power, 5% significance); the target is 10 points (−25%). For clarity it detects 0.13 SD; the target, 0.2 SD, is a small but real shift. Pilot Authorship counts only changed plans and self-started decisions, so both arms are measured the same way.
Walden's interruptions	**~12 / month**	At most 3 a week, against ~1,500 agent actions a month (illustrative: ~50 a day).

Aarav, Orbit and prototype numbers are illustrative; targets are hypotheses. Name: Thoreau, *Walden* (1854).